

# William Hazlitt

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William Hazlitt was born in Maidstone in 1778, the youngest son of a Unitarian minister. Educated in Hackney, London, he was influenced by Joseph Priestley and developed strong beliefs in liberty and the rights of individuals. Early friendships with Coleridge and Wordsworth inspired his interest in poetry and philosophy, while he also trained as a painter, producing portraits of friends, though they were rarely flattering.

Hazlitt married twice and had a troubled personal life, including affairs and financial difficulties. From 1812, he became a journalist, essayist, and critic, contributing to the *Morning Chronicle* and *The Examiner*. He admired Napoleon and often wrote on politics and society.

Despite personal scandals and failing friendships, Hazlitt produced celebrated works such as *Characters of Shakespeare's Plays* and *Table Talk*. He died in Soho, London, in 1830, leaving a legacy as one of England's greatest essayists.



*William Hazlitt*